national media shamelessly blacked out the Yatra, the regional media and social media lit up every home with the lights and heat emanating from the torches of the Yatra. The clever symbolism of the Bharat Jodo Yatra's entry had successfully captured Maharashtra's attention.

But for those of us who had taken this leap of faith by joining and mobilizing for the Yatra, the substance was more crucial than the symbolism. For us, this was an opportunity to not just educate ourselves on Rahul's sincerity, but also the Congress's integrity and ability. After all, what mattered most to most of us was not a political party, but the defence of the constitutional values we love. And so I, along with a host of others, carefully began observing the Bharat Jodo Yatra.

About 4,000 to 5,000 new people from Maharashtra joined the Yatra every day, so our ranks kept swelling. Without fail, this sea of people (which was fast becoming an ocean) would start sharp at 6 a.m. with the flag-hoisting. The Congress Seva Dal would lead the Yatra, proudly holding aloft the Indian flag. The first part of the day included a brisk walk of about 15 kilometres, after which it would halt around 10 a.m. (when the sun became unbearable). The yatris rested until 3 p.m. while Rahul Gandhi, Digvijaya Singh, Jairam Ramesh, Nana Patole, Ashok Chavan, Balasaheb Thorat and other state Congress leaders typically met one or two civil society groups (ranging from twenty to forty). These conversations were interactive, honest and thought-provoking. Over and above the fourteen interactions we had proposed, there were countless other requests from Congress leaders, professional groups and a host of civil society organizations. Accommodating more than a hundred requests from competing stakeholders in fourteen days must have been exceptionally difficult, but the organizers somehow achieved the impossible. Every single person was accommodated—either in the sitting or walking interactions.

I myself had the honour of attending two interactions—one was a closed-door sitting interaction with writers, poets, Sufis and other progressive thinkers. The other was as a translator for warkaris who walked with Rahul. The first was formally organized under the aegis of Dakshinayan on 11 November at Kalamnuri. Loosely titled 'Prabodhanache